

My kids are pretty bratty, will this actually work?

Yes. And it's not just me saying that.

A researcher called Tim Kasser did a study called the 'Materialism Intervention'. He picked a group of spoilt kids and got them to keep a 'give jar', donate to people who needed it, and do some volunteer work. And he also set up a control group of kids who did none of these things.

His research found that kids who had the intervention showed sustained increases in self-esteem over time, whereas their counterparts in the control group experienced decreases in self-esteem.

And the best part is, it lasted: 10 months after the initial study, those same bratty kids reported that their wellbeing was still improving.

Do I have to give food?

Let me be clear: I'm not trying to be an activist, or to tell you that you *have* to get your kids to give food. This is about teaching your kids a life lesson—by using the money in their Give Jar. Donating food happens to be an effective way to do this, as all kids understand hunger. But if you'd prefer your family to volunteer for or donate to a different cause, go ahead.

Should I give to homeless people on the street when I'm with my kids?

I do. It's not really about the person begging (or what he spends my coins on); it's about my kids.

My boys are being raised in a little country town, so they really notice it when we head into the city. And I've seen them look at a homeless person, then look at me to see if I'll ignore someone who's obviously hurting.

It's also why I end up buying multiple copies of *The Big Issue* when we're walking downtown. We get to talk to the sellers and learn a little bit about their lives. Sometimes they explain they were homeless but are now getting back on their feet. Everyone needs some kindness.